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Article

Relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity in social studies: Teachers' developing understandings of their relationship

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Highlights:
- Teachers initially treated relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity separately in their discussions.
- Teachers increasingly articulated them as interconnected, relational pedagogy enabling multiperspectivity.
- Demonstrates how teachers describe relational work as shaping classroom climate and participation.
- Shows how teachers develop concrete strategies for addressing multiple perspectives in classroom practice.

Purpose: This study explores how social studies teachers understand and relate multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy when teaching content perceived as sensitive or controversial.

Design/methodology/approach: The study draws on a two-year participatory research circle with teachers. Data from workshop discussions were analysed thematically, focusing on how teachers' understandings developed over time.

Findings: The findings show a shift from treating the approaches as separate to understanding relational pedagogy as a key condition for working with multiperspectivity. Trust-based relationships were perceived as enabling student participation and engagement with multiple perspectives. Analytically, this relationship can be understood as the coordination of *social and symbolic milieus*, making joint action around complex content possible.

Research limitations/implications: The context-specific sample limits generalizability. The findings are based on teachers' perspectives and do not include direct observations of classroom practice or independent measures of student learning. Future research should examine diverse settings and student experiences.

Practical implications: The study conceptualises teaching complex content as requiring the coordination of relational and epistemic dimensions of classroom practice.

Keywords: social studies education, relational pedagogy, multiperspectivity, sensitive and controversial issues (SCI), joint action

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1 INTRODUCTION

Teaching subjects that fall under the umbrella of social studies often involves addressing issues that may be perceived as either sensitive, difficult or controversial in the classroom (Cowan & Maitles, 2012; Hess, 2009; A. Larsson et al., 2025). Subjects such as history, civics, religious education, and geography frequently engage with themes that are both personally relevant to students and socially significant beyond the classroom. Such issues may give rise to challenging classroom situations, particularly when discussions become emotionally charged or develop in unanticipated ways (Cassar et al., 2021).

One way of approaching these challenges is to support students in engaging with multiple perspectives. Multiperspectivity refers to recognising that social phenomena can be interpreted in different ways and that several perspectives may be considered reasonable (Wansink et al., 2018). Previous research has highlighted both the importance of multiperspectivity and the difficulties teachers encounter when attempting to incorporate it into their teaching, particularly in relation to complex or sensitive issues (Abbey & Wansink, 2022; Bruen & Grammes, 2016; A. Larsson et al., 2025). One such difficulty that appears to be crucial is the emotional uncertainty perceived by teachers when multiple perspectives are addressed in the classroom (Abbey and Wansink, 2022; Bruen & Grammes, 2016).

Another line of research has focused on the relational conditions of classroom practice. Studies on relational pedagogy and classroom emotions emphasise the importance of trust, teacher–student relationships, and the ways in which classroom interactions shape what can be expressed and explored in teaching (Aspelin & Persson, 2011; Blennow, 2019; Keegan, 2021; A. Larsson & L. Larsson, 2021; A. Larsson & Ledman, 2025; Zembylas, 2018). Within social studies education, this relational dimension is particularly significant, as classroom discussions intersect with broader societal discourses while also being embedded in students' personal experiences (Kloeg, 2022).

While both multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy have been highlighted as important in social studies education, less attention has been paid to how these dimensions relate to one another in teachers' practice. Research has shown that teaching for multiperspectivity involves a number of challenges (Abbey & Wansink, 2022), one of which concerns the emotional demands it places on both teachers and students. The emphasis on trust and safe classroom relationships in relational pedagogy may therefore offer a way of addressing these difficulties. As a starting point, there is a need for empirically grounded studies that examine how teachers understand this relationship.

This article addresses this need by examining how social studies teachers, within a participatory research setting, make sense of and describe the relationship between multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy in their teaching.

The research question guiding this study is:

- How do social studies teachers understand and articulate the relationship between multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy in their teaching practice over time?

2 A RATIONALE FOR ADDRESSING MULTIPERSPECTIVITY AND RELATIONAL APPROACHES

In line with Kello (2016), we use the term sensitive and controversial issues (SCI) to capture forms of educational content that, across different contexts and subject areas, are variously conceptualised as controversial issues (Kjøstvedt & Jøsok, 2024), difficult histories (Epstein & Peck, 2017), and sensitive issues (Lowe, 2015). Rather than treating these separately, we use a composite

concept to foreground their shared didactic challenges. We do this as we seek to understand how the didactic approaches of multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy are perceived by teachers in relation to this broader domain. By employing a composite term, we direct attention to forms of teaching content which tend to pose distinct challenges for classroom interaction, often characterised by affective intensity and epistemic openness. In the school subjects that in Sweden fall under the umbrella of social studies (history, geography, religion, and civics/social science), SCI often become part of classroom teaching (A. Larsson & Ledman, 2025). Previous research has approached the teaching of such issues in different ways, including deliberative and agonistic perspectives. While deliberative approaches emphasise consensus-oriented discussion in democratic classrooms (Englund, 2006; Ruitenberg, 2009), other contributions highlight the importance of making disagreement visible and sustaining pluralism (Mouffe, 2011; Tryggvason, 2019, 2021).

Moving beyond this line of research, recent work has emphasised students' capacity to engage with disagreement, for example, through the idea of becoming "disagreeing citizens" (Dahl, 2024). One way of conceptualising such capacities is through multiperspectivity, understood here as acknowledging that multiple, equally legitimate perspectives on a phenomenon can exist. Multiperspectivity has been highlighted as a relevant didactic approach in several studies on social studies subjects. In history education, Abbey and Wansink (2022) identified ten obstacles to multiperspectivity, four of which are particularly relevant to our study: both teachers and students may feel emotionally uncomfortable addressing controversial issues from multiple perspectives; they may be reluctant to accept that different perspectives can be reasonable; sufficient knowledge about the phenomenon may be lacking; and teachers may not allow diverse perspectives to be expressed in the classroom. Kropman et al. (2021) found that teachers struggle to plan lessons where multiperspectivity is foregrounded, and showed that teachers' epistemological beliefs and interpretations of the curriculum strongly influence their ability to include it in teaching. Wansink et al. (2018) identify time constraints, both in planning and instruction, and a lack of teaching materials as factors that hinder teachers from incorporating multiperspectivity. In civics education, Bruen and Grammes (2016) examined how university teachers develop multiperspectivity, showing that teachers initially feel uncertain and face challenges such as time pressure, large student groups, and the need for thorough preparation.

In the research presented, the issue of classroom relationships is implicit, particularly in Abbey and Wansink (2022), who argue that emotional insecurity is a factor hindering multiperspectivity. In Keegan's (2021) research on SCI in the political classroom, the concept of *political affective literacy* is introduced as a way to articulate what Wansink et al. (2018) point to. Keegan, like Zembylas (2018), argues that emotions matter in the classroom and that students need to learn how to manage emotions and understand their role in politics. Increasing political polarisation is both driven by emotions and triggers emotional outbursts. Therefore, emotional literacy must be cultivated in classrooms filled with political questions that generate tensions and controversies (Keegan, 2021). Numerous studies on teaching politics and social issues conclude that we need more knowledge about how emotional boundaries are managed in classrooms (Blennow, 2019; A. Larsson & L. Larsson, 2021; A. Larsson et al., 2025).

In Sweden, *relational pedagogy* has been introduced as a pedagogical tool for managing emotions in the classroom (Aspelin & Persson, 2011). The concept is based on social-psychological assumptions that schools are spaces where people meet and co-construct knowledge.

Internationally, the anthology *No Education Without Relation* (Bingham & Sidorkin, 2004) can be seen as a starting point for relational education, although social psychology within sociological and psychological traditions has a much longer history. Aspelin and Persson (2011) argue that their work highlights how teachers can develop greater awareness of how they act and learn together with students. Aspelin and Eklöf (2023) show that a single moment can significantly affect students' classroom conditions and learning. If a student experiences something that causes shame or loss of face, this can have major consequences for future learning opportunities. We agree with the position that such interactions should not be avoided at all costs; rather, developing the competence to determine whether, and in what ways, to engage in them constructively should be regarded as an essential part of teachers' instructional practice (Aspelin, 2023; Aspelin & Eklöf, 2023). However, as Reeves & Mare (2017) demonstrate, teachers often struggle to operationalise relational pedagogy in their classrooms.

Although studies indicate that both multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy are important in teaching complex issues, research directly addressing their relationship remains limited. Existing work suggests that emotional insecurity may hinder engagement with multiple perspectives (Abbey & Wansink, 2022), while other studies point to the importance of classroom relationships for enabling participation and learning (Fan, 2012; Ljungblad, 2016; Xie & Derakhshan, 2021). Taken together, these findings indicate a potential connection between relational conditions and multiperspectival work that warrants further investigation. This study addresses this gap by examining how teachers understand and articulate this relationship in practice.

3 METHODOLOGY: A PARTICIPATORY RESEARCH CIRCLE APPROACH

This study was conducted as a research circle, which is a participatory form of knowledge development in which practitioners and researchers engage in a shared and iterative learning process. Its purpose is to create a dialogical arena where experiential and scientific knowledge can be integrated and developed collaboratively (Persson, 2008).

The research circle extended over a two-year period and comprised six workshops, each lasting approximately two hours and held in person. The workshops followed Persson's (2008) model and included three recurring components: experience-sharing among participants, theoretical input from the researchers, and joint reflection and analysis. In this way, the workshops functioned not only as sites of data generation but also as part of an ongoing process of professional learning and knowledge co-construction.

While the workshops involved collective discussions that share some features with focus group interviews (Wibeck, 2010), they differ in important respects. Rather than capturing participants' views at a single point in time, the research circle was designed as an iterative process in which teachers tested ideas in their own teaching between sessions and brought these experiences back for further discussion. The empirical material thus reflects how teachers' understandings were articulated, negotiated, and, in some cases, developed over time.

The researchers took an active and facilitative role throughout the research circle. In addition to organising and guiding the workshops, they participated in the discussions, introduced theoretical perspectives, and followed the development of teachers' reflections over time. This position can be understood in relation to Gold's (1958) classic distinction between different observer roles, as the

researchers' involvement went beyond that of detached observation. Rather than occupying a single, fixed position, their role combined elements of participation and observation.

From an ethnographic perspective, such an approach resonates with accounts of engaged and reflexive participation, where the researcher is both involved in and analytically attentive to social interaction (Atkinson, 2015). In this study, the researchers were thus part of the knowledge-generating process while at the same time analysing how meanings were constructed and negotiated in the workshop discussions.

The researchers facilitated the workshops, introduced theoretical perspectives, and selected the teaching materials used as points of departure for discussion. A municipal support material on teaching the Israel-Palestine conflict was chosen as a shared reference point, as it represents a topic commonly perceived as complex and potentially sensitive, difficult or controversial in social studies education. The material, published in 2022, consists of two main components: (1) four didactic approaches, multiperspectivity, relational pedagogy, multicultural pedagogy, and historical consciousness and identity, and (2) a historical account of the Israel-Palestine conflict, complemented by texts presenting nuanced perspectives from both pro-Israeli and pro-Palestinian positions.

An initial preparatory meeting was conducted with 20 teachers who had expressed interest in the project. During this meeting, teachers discussed the relevance of the material in relation to their teaching. A shared view that emerged was that the Israel-Palestine conflict was rarely addressed as a discrete topic but rather appeared in relation to other content, such as World War I, World War II, the Holocaust, or human rights. Teachers, therefore, expressed that the historical content of the material would be difficult to integrate without major adjustments to their teaching.

At the same time, teachers highlighted a perceived lack of practically applicable didactic strategies, particularly in relation to handling disagreement and multiple perspectives in classroom interaction. For this reason, they expressed a particular interest in further developing their understanding of the didactic approaches included in the material, especially multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy. These two approaches, therefore, became the main focus of the research circle.

When the research circle began, six months after the preparatory meeting, eight teachers from four schools participated. Six teachers worked in lower secondary education (ages 12–15), and two in upper secondary education (ages 16–18). Participation varied across the workshops due to practical constraints, and attendance gradually decreased over time, with two teachers participating in the final session.

In the support material, multiperspectivity is presented as a didactic approach that recognises the existence of multiple, and sometimes conflicting, narratives about the same phenomenon. Relational pedagogy is described as focusing on the uniqueness of each individual and the importance of interpersonal relationships for learning. While the material provides conceptual descriptions of these approaches, it does not prescribe specific teaching strategies, leaving teachers to interpret and operationalise them in their own practice.

For the analysis, we draw on recorded and transcribed segments of workshop discussions in which teachers engaged with the concepts of multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy. The focus is on how teachers articulated and negotiated their understandings of the relationship between these approaches within the research circle. The analysis thus concerns teachers' perspectives and meaning-making processes, rather than direct observations of classroom practice or student outcomes.

The workshops were guided by a set of open-ended questions focusing on teachers' experiences of working with multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy, as well as the challenges associated

with addressing complex and potential SCIs in the classroom. These questions invited teachers to reflect on concrete teaching situations and to discuss how the two approaches could be understood and enacted in practice. An overview of the guiding questions and workshop themes is provided in Appendix 1. The participating teachers, the schools' characteristics, regarding socio-economic status and the educational level of parents are presented in Table 1.

Table 1: Teachers and school characteristics

Lower secondary schools	*Teachers*	*SES-index of school*
1	Anna, Karin	Ca 150
2	Lars, Johan, Anders	Ca 110
3	Maria	Ca 160
Upper secondary school		*Percentage students with highly educated parents*
1	Erik, Steven	88

The availability of information on student composition varies between lower and upper secondary schools in Sweden. For lower secondary schools, the SES index serves as an indicator of the extent to which students at a given school are expected to encounter learning challenges; a higher SES index signifies a greater anticipated level of difficulty. All three schools served relatively disadvantaged student populations, while the schools with indices of 150 and 160 were situated within the most disadvantaged quartile nationally. The figures in Table 1 have been rounded to prevent the identification of individual schools. For upper secondary schools, the most informative available indicator is the proportion of students with at least one parent holding a post-secondary education of three years or more. At the school in question, this proportion is 88 per cent, placing it at the 95th percentile, meaning that 95 per cent of all upper secondary schools in Sweden have a lower share of students with at least one parent with post-secondary education. The participating teachers represented various social studies subjects and had diverse levels of professional experience, creating conditions for multifaceted discussions on relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity.

3.1 Documentation and analysis

The discussions were documented through field notes and audio recordings. The recordings were transcribed and analysed thematically (Braun & Clarke, 2019). The analysis focused on how participants articulated their views on the didactic approaches and how these conversations evolved over time.

3.2 Ethics and ethical review

The project was reviewed and approved by the Swedish Ethical Review Authority (Ref. No. 2023-04001-01). We avoided collecting personal data but sought ethical approval due to potential risks associated with discussing political and sensitive issues related to ethnicity. Teachers' information is also protected by omitting school names and other personal identifiers. In the presentation of the findings, teachers are referred to using pseudonyms in order to preserve anonymity while allowing for variation in perspectives to be visible. Pseudonyms were selected to reflect the general characteristics of the participant group without indicating identifiable personal attributes. When teachers referred to their students, sensitive political topics occasionally emerged, for example, in relation to parents' political views, but we did not collect any personal data that could be linked to these cases.

3.3 Conceptual tools for analysing relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity

Our point of departure in this study is that teaching involves both teachers and students, it can be described in terms of joint actions, and the social environment in which these actions occur is shaped by an implicit didactic contract (Brousseau, 2002; Ligozat & Almqvist, 2018). This contract should not be understood as a fixed agreement but as a set of expectations continuously renegotiated during the teaching process. A didactic contract encompasses the mutual expectations between teachers and students, as well as the rules, norms, and habits considered reasonable in the classroom (Sensevy, 2012). The enactment of this contract depends on the conditions that structure participation around the content. To conceptualise these conditions, we draw on the concept of *milieu*, which refers to the set of conditions through which teachers and students engage with the content. Although *milieu* may include a variety of material, social, and symbolic dimensions (Brousseau, 2002; Ligozat et al., 2018; Sensevy, 2011), the present study focuses on the latter two because they offer a useful way of analysing how relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity shape the conditions for participation and engagement in classroom practice. Relational aspects in classrooms are understood as contributing to the constitution of a *social milieu*, insofar as patterns of interaction and relationships shape students' opportunities to participate in joint activity around the content. Similarly, work with multiperspectivity is understood as contributing to a *symbolic milieu*, as it provides symbolic resources and interpretative tools through which students can make sense of and engage with the knowledge at stake. These milieus are constituted in and through the didactic situation, as they organise the conditions under which students can make sense of and act in relation to the knowledge at stake. Through teachers' didactic work, these conditions can be arranged in ways that make *joint action* more or less possible, enabling teachers and students to collectively engage with, negotiate, and develop the content under study (Ligozat et al., 2018). The concepts presented above, including milieu, have rarely been applied in studies of social studies education. One exception is Gericke et al. (2018), who used them to analyse teaching about complex subject matter.

4 RESULTS

Below, we present findings from the workshop discussions and conclude the article with a discussion where we analyse how social and symbolic milieus are articulated in teachers' understanding of their teaching. The analysis focuses on how teachers reflected on multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy over time, particularly in relation to teaching content characterised as sensitive and controversial.

4.1 Teachers

The workshop discussions were characterised by an interactive and dynamic conversational form, in which teachers frequently built on each other's contributions. The presentation aims to make visible both recurring patterns and variation in how teachers expressed and developed their understandings. To support this, teachers are referred to using pseudonyms. The excerpts presented below have been selected based on themes that received sustained attention in the discussions, and they are presented in a slightly edited form to enhance readability (e.g., removal of repetitions and fillers), while preserving the meaning of the original contributions.

4.2 Teachers' initial accounts of the didactic approaches

When teachers were first asked to describe their teaching related to multiperspectivity, they tended to focus on the content addressed in the classroom, particularly in relation to history teaching. For example, Anna emphasised the importance of providing a historical background:

> I think it's important to highlight the historical background to increase students' understanding of what happens in different types of wars and conflicts. Teaching should include a longer historical perspective. By working with open questions, students can discuss what happened, why it happened, and how the situation developed into what we see today.

Several teachers framed multiperspectivity primarily in terms of broadening students' understanding of historical developments through extended contextualisation. In these accounts, multiperspectivity was not always explicitly articulated as a distinct didactic approach but appeared to be embedded in how teachers described their work with content.

When prompted more directly to reflect on how different perspectives were made visible in teaching, teachers instead highlighted internal diversity within groups. Johan, for instance, described the importance of challenging simplified dichotomies:

> Important perspectives include showing students that it's not just Jews versus… I mean, even within Israel and within the Palestinian population there are huge conflicts, between the Palestinian Authority and Hamas there are major tensions, and now Israel has almost experienced a civil war over its leadership. That's also important.

As in this example, multiperspectivity was often associated with recognising complexity within groups rather than explicitly contrasting perspectives as part of a structured didactic approach. At the same time, teachers did not consistently use the terms *perspective* or *multiperspectivity* when discussing these issues.

In contrast, relational pedagogy was described as both important and difficult to define. Karin expressed uncertainty about how to articulate the relational dimension of teaching:

> I think the relational aspect is hard to define, maybe. The examples you gave earlier were great, like responding to what students say, but it's difficult. The relational is something that's happening all the time. It's hard to pinpoint: "this is what I do for the relational," because it's really about how you interact with students all the time.

Similar reflections were expressed by other teachers, who described relational pedagogy as something self-evident yet difficult to operationalise in concrete terms.

To summarise, the initial discussions suggest that teachers more readily described their work in terms of subject content than in relation to explicit didactic approaches. While elements of multiperspectivity were present, they were not clearly conceptualised, and relational pedagogy remained important but difficult to define. These observations indicate that multiperspectivity was associated with conceptual challenges, while relational pedagogy tended to be treated as implicit.

Following this initial phase, teachers' understandings began to shift as they engaged more systematically with the literature and reflected on their own teaching.

4.3 Teachers' engagement with the multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy

4.3.1 Initial patterns in the discussions

In the early stages of the research circle, discussions centred mainly on the literature, and teachers' reflections were often relatively general in character. Teachers highlighted the clarity of the multiperspectivity framework (Wansink et al., 2018), describing it as providing clearer conceptual guidance than they were accustomed to. In the discussions, the article was more frequently related to than the literature on relational pedagogy that teachers had also read. For example, Anna commented on the perceived clarity of the article:

> I find it more concrete; they define what multiperspectivity can be. And then, as a teacher, I can start thinking about how to use these perspectives, it triggers more concrete ideas for me as a teacher.

Similar reflections were expressed by other teachers, who nevertheless described multiperspectivity as a relatively unfamiliar concept in their practice. At the same time, the discussions highlighted that translating the concept into teaching required both subject knowledge and suitable materials. Johan, for instance, emphasised the demands multiperspectivity places on teachers:

> I agree that this was a bit more concrete, but to work with multiperspectivity, you need to be well-informed. And maybe we are, as social studies teachers, but you also need solid material to start from, it won't happen by itself. You need examples, and I like this, but then you need something about those perspectives. The challenge is finding time for this within the teaching schedule. It comes at the expense of something else.

As in this example, teachers pointed to both conceptual and practical challenges. Multiperspectivity was described as requiring careful preparation, access to appropriate materials, and time within an already constrained curriculum.

These accounts indicate that limited subject knowledge, time constraints, and lack of resources may pose barriers to implementing multiperspectivity in practice. In contrast, a somewhat different pattern emerged in discussions of relational pedagogy. Here, teachers tended to describe the literature (Aspelin & Persson, 2011) as more abstract and less directly applicable to their everyday practice. Karin, for example, reflected on the role of time in relation to relational work:

> It said you want more time to work with students, but in practice it's so stressful. You have so many in front of you, how do you find time for that? I wrote "time" in many places. Time to achieve this presence, these moments they talk about.

Similar concerns were raised by other teachers, who described relational work as central but difficult to realise within existing conditions. This tension highlights a gap between the perceived importance of the didactic approaches and the practical constraints shaping teachers' work.

4.3.2 Emerging patterns in the discussions

As the research circle progressed, a shift could be observed in how teachers described the two approaches. Later discussions increasingly emphasised classroom relationships and group dynamics as central to what can be achieved in teaching. For example, Lars highlighted how classroom dynamics shaped the conditions for teaching:

> It's also about a feeling of safety, you know. It becomes very difficult to teach a class that doesn't function as a group.

Such reflections point to an emerging awareness among teachers that classroom relationships and group dynamics are central to what can be achieved in teaching. As the discussions progressed, the literature on relational pedagogy was also engaged with in more concrete terms. Teachers began to describe specific practices and organisational conditions that could support relational work.

Maria, for instance, reflected on the role of structured opportunities for building relationships with students:

> One interesting thing the book mentioned was that teachers and students have individual meetings scheduled. It's kind of like a mentor-student setup, and that can really help strengthen the class. If people feel seen, safe, and listened to, the group can get stronger too. But in some classes, you really have to work hard on that, and I find it challenging. Sometimes we have theme days, to combat racism and things like that, which is a good idea, but I think the relational part has to be there all the time. It's about building that group mentality and mutual respect. I notice a big difference in group dynamics when we've had such days regularly, like mentor days, where we actually focus on relationships and getting to know the students.

In accounts such as this, relational pedagogy was no longer described primarily in abstract terms but linked to concrete practices aimed at strengthening both individual teacher-student relationships and the collective classroom environment. At the same time, teachers pointed to structural constraints, such as time and organisational conditions, that influenced the extent to which such practices could be implemented.

The relationship between relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity also became more explicitly articulated in these later discussions. Erik, for example, described how relational work could be understood as a foundation for engaging with multiple perspectives:

> I think these approaches go very much hand in hand, but I see a big advantage in working first on the relational aspect and then moving into, "OK, what opinions and feelings exist in this class about what we're teaching, and what different perspectives might be behind that?" Then we can work more with multiperspectivity when we're on solid ground. So, for me: relational work first, then figure out how to handle multiperspectivity.

As in this example, several teachers described a sequence in which relational work was seen as enabling engagement with multiple perspectives, particularly in situations involving differing opinions and emotional responses.

Taken together, these discussions suggest a shift from content-focused descriptions to an increasing emphasis on relational conditions as enabling multiperspectival work. As teachers' understandings of the didactic approaches became more explicit, they also began to articulate concrete strategies for enacting them in practice.

4.3.3 Teachers' strategies for relational pedagogy

Teachers articulated several strategies for relational pedagogy, many of which focused on building trust and creating a sense of security in the classroom. For example, presenting multiple sides of an issue was described as important for maintaining students' trust in the teacher. Anna, for example, reflected on how this influenced students' trust:

> Not just thinking about when things go wrong, but having a good relationship with the students. Because generally, they do listen to you, they trust that you're not pro-Palestine or pro-Israel. That they don't label you, but trust that you're trying to strike a balance. When it comes to these difficult topics, it's easier if the groups have confidence in you.

In this account, trust is closely tied to how the teacher handles subject content, illustrating how relational and subject-related dimensions intersect. Similar concerns were raised by other teachers, who described perceived impartiality as important for maintaining students' confidence in the teacher.

When the discussions turned to creating a sense of security in the classroom, teachers emphasised the need to consider students both as individuals and as members of a group. Johan, for instance, highlighted how students' contributions affect peer relations:

> Always pick up on what students say. Because it affects what all the other students think about that student. It's not just about that person's self-confidence but also about what everyone else thinks of them. It's not only the relationship between me and the student, it's also about the relationship that the student has with the rest of the class.

Relational work was also linked to how teachers responded to students' contributions, both to support individuals and to shape peer relations. Strategies included acknowledging contributions, fostering positive interactions, and maintaining an open stance while setting boundaries. In discussions about how to handle critical or negative student expressions, Karin emphasised the importance of maintaining an encouraging, open and curious stance:

> Students find it easier to express negativity and what they don't like. But then you have to train them: What's positive about this? That's where relational pedagogy can provide a foundation. When students express things they might not fully understand yet, we always respond with curiosity, wanting to learn together. Not like: "No, you can't think that, period."

This quote underscores the importance of open communication, boundary-setting, and responding to students in ways that support participation without causing loss of face. What teachers describe here can be related to the idea of affective literacy. Teachers' discussions pointed to two interrelated dimensions of relational work: relationships with individual students and the classroom as a social group. These relationships were seen as a prerequisite for introducing multiple perspectives.

Across the discussions, relational work was described as closely connected to students' willingness to participate in discussions involving multiple perspectives, highlighting the importance of teacher–student relationships and classroom climate for enabling dialogue.

4.3.4 Teachers' strategies for multiperspectivity

In parallel, teachers described a range of strategies for supporting engagement with multiple perspectives. One strategy involved structured tools such as tables. Anna explained:

> An exercise with a table that you fill in based on different perspectives. Then it becomes a concrete material with a pedagogical purpose, instead of just a text. The contents of texts addressing how different groups view the issue can be transferred into the table so students can visualise it. It could be women's suffrage or industrialisation. That's something we really need to do more of.

As in this example, teachers emphasised the importance of making different groups and their perspectives visible in a structured way.

Teachers also highlighted the role of question design. Johan noted:

> It's important to have sufficiently interesting questions. But then you can also give instructions in the assignment that they should show multiple perspectives. We've done something similar with Napoleon: Was he a power-hungry tyrant or a hero? Or Gustav Vasa: father of the nation or tyrant? Even students who really like Napoleon… In the end, there isn't a single student who doesn't understand that they need to see pros and cons in everything.

In these accounts, multiperspectivity was described both as a way of structuring content and as a way of encouraging students to consider contrasting interpretations.

Teachers also described multiperspectivity as a potential resource for addressing polarisation. Karin, for example, reflected on how students' thinking differed from public debate:

> This polarisation, when you listen to public debate, it often seems like there are two sides: one good, the other evil. I'm not sure it's really like that. When I talk to young people, I sometimes get the impression they're less locked in their thinking than adults. If you can break that pattern in the classroom, you can avoid the "if you don't agree with me, you're evil" mindset. So maybe multiperspectivity can help us avoid that kind of polarisation? That might be the overarching goal, the reason I think it's a good pedagogical approach.

As in this example, teachers view multiperspectivity as a way of countering simplified "either-or" thinking and building on students' relative openness. At the same time, they also noted that working with multiple perspectives could be challenging for students, particularly when issues were emotionally charged.

A further strategy discussed by the teachers was how to sequence teaching in relation to the emotional intensity of different topics. Erik, for instance, described working with less emotionally charged issues before moving toward more sensitive or controversial ones:

> You can start with a lot of the cold history. Go back to conflicts that don't evoke strong emotions and move between perspectives. Talking about hot and cold topics can make the cold ones more engaging. Students can start to see that the cold resembles the hot, and you can cool down the hot when it gets too close. Moving between hot and cold can become a pedagogical strategy that works.

In accounts such as this, teachers described how working with "colder" topics could help students become familiar with the idea of multiperspectivity before applying it in relation to possible SCI issues. This approach was seen as a way of reducing the risk that strong emotions would hinder classroom discussions (cf. Wansink et al., 2018).

Taken together, these quotes show how teachers moved from viewing multiperspectivity as an abstract principle to enacting it through more structured and deliberate classroom practices.

4.3.5 Teachers' perceptions of changes in classroom climate and student engagement

At the end of the research circle, teachers reflected on how their evolving understandings had influenced their classroom practice and classroom environment. Several teachers described changes in how they approached their teaching. Anna, for example, noted:

> Well, our teaching has definitely been influenced by our conversations during the meetings. We now constantly keep these approaches in mind, and we work with them much more explicitly. I want to work in a way that makes the students feel involved, seen, heard, and listened to.

When the discussion turned to the classroom environment, teachers initially emphasised relational aspects. They described changes not only at the level of individual students, but also in the class as a social group. Maria reflected on how group dynamics had developed:

> You can see it in who they are as people, and who they are as a class, and even how the class interacts with other teachers. Yes, and how much everyone has gotten to know each other. Even teachers who aren't particularly skilled at working with relational pedagogy have still gotten to know the group, because the group itself has become more secure together. Working with the group has made an enormous difference, and you can really see the change. The students dare more now, they're not afraid of losing face in front of each other, and they feel safe enough to support one another. You don't see that in classes where you haven't worked a lot with this.

In accounts such as this, teachers described an increased sense of security, which they associated with greater student participation in classroom discussions. The issue of "losing face," which had been discussed earlier in the workshops, was here linked to students' readiness to express their views in front of peers.

The conversation also addressed how work with multiperspectivity was reflected in classroom interactions. Anna, for example, described how students appeared to engage differently with subject content:

> They reflect more now and can use several perspectives. It's easier for my students to see these perspectives. It has become easier for them to change their minds when they encounter new facts about an issue.

Statements such as this indicate that teachers perceived changes in how students engaged with multiple perspectives, including a greater willingness to reconsider their initial positions. Several teachers linked these perceived changes to the relational conditions in the classroom, suggesting that students' engagement with different perspectives depended on feeling secure enough to express their views.

To summarise, these reflections suggest a perceived relationship between relational pedagogy, classroom climate, and students' engagement with multiperspectivity, while also underlining the interpretive nature of such observations.

5 DISCUSSION

5.1 Integrating relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity in practice

In this section, we discuss the results through the lenses provided by the concepts used in the study. We proceed from the assumption that the aim of classroom practice is to engage teachers and students in joint action, that is, to collaboratively work on and develop curricular content. To illuminate this process, we draw on the didactic triangle. As an analytical device, the triangle helps us distinguish between two interdependent dimensions of classroom practice: a social milieu and a symbolic milieu. In the present study, relational pedagogy is examined in relation to the former, whereas multiperspectivity is examined in relation to the latter. While analytically separable, these

dimensions are empirically intertwined. Their coordination is important because it shapes the conditions for *joint action*, understood here as the coordinated engagement of teachers and students with the knowledge content that constitutes the object of teaching. In the didactic triangle (see Figure 1), joint action is illustrated through the solid bidirectional arrow spanning the apex between teacher and student. This symbolises the possibility of teaching and learning developing into joint action, a situation that is more likely when relational pedagogy contributes to a constructive social milieu, represented by the horizontal solid bidirectional arrow.

Figure 1: Constructive use of relational pedagogy

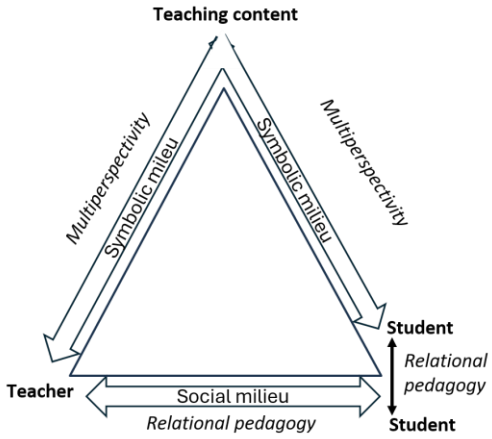
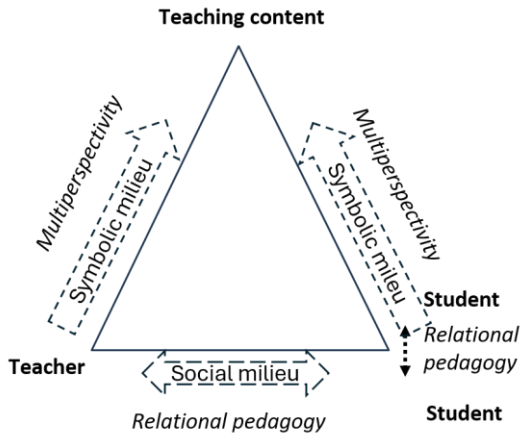


Figure 2: Unconstructive use of relational pedagogy



When teachers in our study described working systematically with relational pedagogy, they emphasised building trust-based relationships with students and fostering positive peer relationships. According to the teachers, these relationships contributed to a sense of security in the classroom, enabling them to address SCI from multiple perspectives and establish *joint action* around this type of content (Sensevy, 2012). We argue that such relational work is crucial for establishing the constructive social milieu, which both facilitates the discussion of SCI and supports students' engagement with them. In Figure 1, this is illustrated by the solid arrow between teacher and students. At the apex of the triangle lies the teaching content. When the social and symbolic milieus support one another, students and teachers are better positioned to engage with this content collectively, represented by the bidirectional arrow spanning the apex of the triangle. The findings suggest that participation is strengthened when trust-based relationships and engagement with multiperspectivity are aligned.

However, when either dimension is weakened, the conditions for joint action become more limited (see Figure 2). In such circumstances, when social relations in the classroom are not constructive, a productive social milieu fails to emerge, as represented by the short dashed arrow in Figure 2. We argue that this may hinder the development of joint action around the teaching content, particularly when addressing sensitive issues. This is illustrated by the shorter dashed arrows extending from the teacher and the student, neither of which reaches the apex of the triangle.

In the model presented above, we suggest a way of conceptualising how the social and symbolic milieus are intertwined in classroom practice. The possibility of engaging students in joint action depends on how these milieus are coordinated. This points to an important implication: relational pedagogy should not be treated as self-evident but as a deliberate didactic practice that supports the

development of a constructive social milieu upon which multiperspectival work depends. Building on this, the following section discusses the implications of these findings for teaching practice.

5.2 Elevating relational pedagogy as a deliberate didactic tool

Our analysis suggests that relational pedagogy, when treated as a conscious and explicit didactic tool, plays a significant role in how teachers approach teaching in social studies. For this approach to contribute to a constructive social milieu, teachers and schools need to work as deliberately with it as with didactic strategies more directly linked to content, including teaching that addresses SCI. Teaching, particularly when addressing such issues, places simultaneous demands on both relational and multiperspectival dimensions of classroom practice, as students are invited to engage with multiple perspectives while navigating emotionally and socially complex interactions. This becomes particularly evident when the findings are considered in relation to previous research. A range of challenges associated with implementing multiperspectivity has been identified, including limited subject knowledge, time constraints, and difficulties in handling emotionally charged classroom situations (Abbey & Wansink, 2022; Bruen & Grammes, 2016; Kropman et al., 2021). The present study extends this research by showing how such challenges are closely related to the relational conditions of classroom practice. While earlier research has highlighted the importance of teacher–student relationships and classroom climate (Aspelin & Persson, 2011; Zembylas, 2018), these dimensions have often been treated separately from how content is organised in teaching. Our findings suggest that this separation is analytically limiting. Rather, relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity can be understood as interdependent, as engagement with multiple perspectives relies on trust-based social relations and shared norms of classroom interaction. From this perspective, teaching complex and potentially sensitive content can be understood as requiring the coordination of social and symbolic milieus. These findings thus contribute by showing how relational and content-oriented dimensions of teaching are not simply complementary, but mutually constitutive in classroom practice.

The difficulties observed in the initial teacher discussions in this study indicate that the relational dimension of teaching is often taken for granted or addressed implicitly. This carries the risk that the implementation of relational pedagogy may depend on individual teachers' dispositions rather than being developed as a shared professional practice, thereby limiting the possibilities for establishing joint action. In the teachers' quotes, working systematically with these approaches was associated with creating conditions in which students were more willing to express, negotiate, and reconsider different perspectives. This suggests that the relationship between relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity is not given but emerges through teachers' deliberate efforts to integrate relational and content-related dimensions of teaching.

6. CONCLUSION

This study has examined how teachers understand and describe their work with the two didactic approaches, multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy, within a participatory research setting. The findings show that, while the two approaches were initially treated as separate entities and relational pedagogy was largely taken for granted, requiring no particular attention, teachers increasingly came to articulate them as closely interconnected over time. In particular, relational pedagogy was described as creating the conditions necessary for engaging with multiple

perspectives in classroom practice. More specifically, the findings suggest that this relationship can be understood in terms of the coordination of social and symbolic milieus, which together make joint actions around SCI possible.

The study contributes by demonstrating that this relationship is not self-evident but emerges through teachers' collaborative reflection and deliberate efforts to integrate relational and content-oriented dimensions of teaching. In doing so, it highlights the importance of treating relational pedagogy not as an implicit aspect of teaching, but as a conscious and strategic didactic practice.

These findings suggest that supporting teachers' work with multiperspectivity requires attention not only to subject content and instructional strategies, but also to the relational conditions under which classroom interaction unfolds. Future research could further explore how such approaches are enacted in different contexts and how they relate to students' experiences of participation and learning.

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CONFLICTS OF INTEREST

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

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APPENDIX 1

Overview of workshop structure and guiding activities

This appendix provides an overview of the structure and progression of the research circle workshops. The workshops were designed as an iterative and participatory process in which teachers engaged with relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity through discussion, reflection, and experimentation in practice. The workshops served both as sites of data generation and as part of an ongoing process of professional learning.

Workshop 1: Structured dialogue and initial exploration
The first workshop was based on *The Power of Protocols* (McDonald et al., 2015). Elements from the protocol structure were adapted to fit the design of the research circle.

- Steps 2 and 5 were based on "openers" described in the book, aiming to engage all participants and initiate discussion.
- Steps 5–10 were adapted from the Consultancy Protocol (pp. 31–32), with modifications to accommodate multiple presenters (approximately five per group), ensuring that all participants had the opportunity to contribute.

Discussions were conducted in small groups and were divided into two parts:

- one focusing on multiperspectivity
- one focusing on relational pedagogy

Examples of guiding questions used in this workshop included:

- How do you currently work with multiple perspectives in your teaching?
- What challenges do you encounter when addressing complex or controversial issues?
- How do relationships in the classroom influence students' willingness to participate in discussions?

Workshop 2: Discussion of core literature
This workshop focused on two key texts distributed in advance:

- Aspelin & Persson – Relational pedagogy
- Wansink et al. – Multiperspectivity

Discussions followed the same structure as Workshop 1:

- small-group discussions
- two thematic parts (multiperspectivity and relational pedagogy)

The purpose was to deepen conceptual understanding and connect theoretical perspectives to participants' teaching practice.

Workshop 3: Consolidation and forward planning
The third workshop focused on:

- revisiting the overall aim of the project
- clarifying the direction of the work
- identifying participants' needs and priorities

Teachers also engaged in discussions of additional articles on the two didactic approaches, working in smaller groups.

Workshop 4: Joint discussion and practice-based reflection
Due to a smaller number of participants, discussions were conducted in a shared setting rather than in separate groups.
The focus was on:

- reflecting on teaching experiences
- discussing how the approaches had been implemented
- identifying necessary adjustments

Discussions were grounded in concrete classroom examples.

Workshop 5: Interim analysis and synthesis
The researchers (Janna and David) initiated the session by summarizing the current stage of the project and reconnecting to the key concepts of relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity.

Between Workshops 5 and 6:

- all recorded workshop discussions were reviewed
- a synthesized document was produced and distributed to participants

The aim was to support a more explicit phase of collective reflection and analysis. Key themes included:

- lessons learned
- emerging conclusions
- possibilities for further development and dissemination

Workshop 6: Reflective analysis and future directions
The final workshop was structured around the following guiding question:

- How can we understand the teaching practices developed through work with relational pedagogy and multiperspectivity?

The purpose was to:

- deepen understanding of teachers' practices
- reflect on how teaching may have been influenced by the discussions and literature
- explore how insights could be shared with a broader audience

Participants were also invited to consider:

- possibilities for dissemination
- potential forms of publication (individually or collaboratively)

Across the workshops, recurring guiding questions also included:

- What does it mean in practice to work with multiperspectivity in your teaching?
- How do you create conditions in which students feel safe to express and reconsider different perspectives?
- What tensions arise when combining subject content with relational work in the classroom?

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